

Research question and research objectives

Research question and research objectives

- set the mission, vision and direction for your research

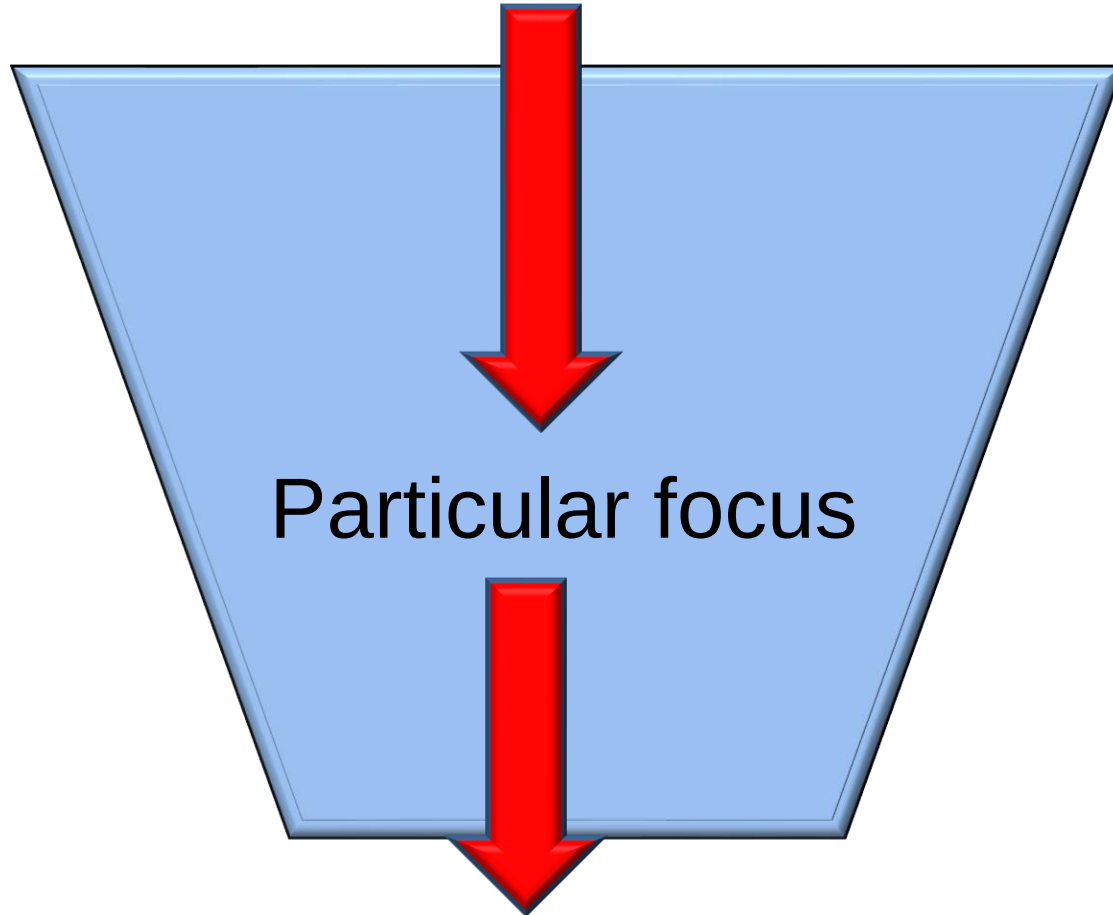
Research question

What will you find out by doing your research?

Research objectives

Set out the areas that you intend to research and what you hope to do with the information gained.

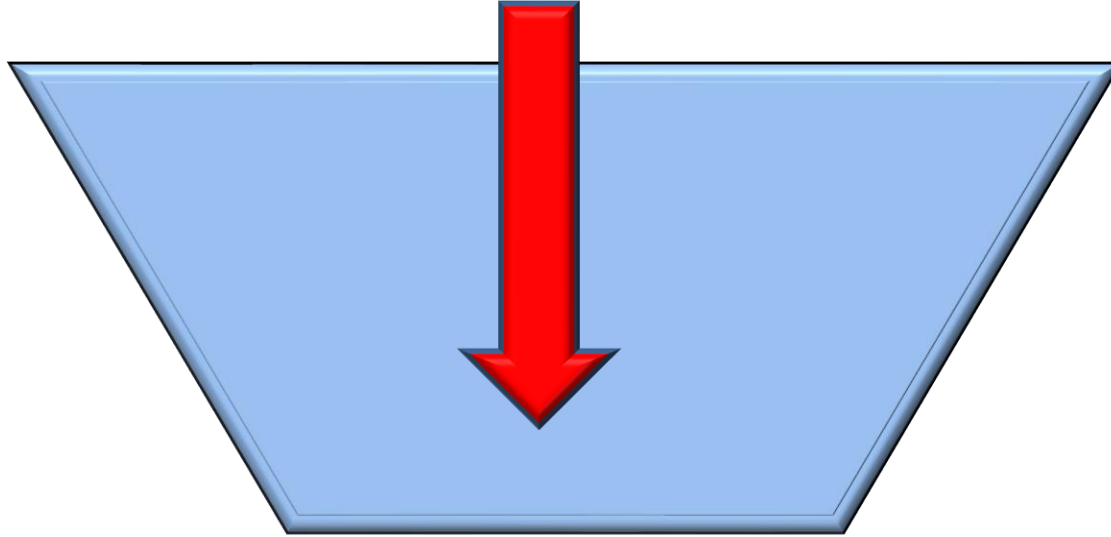
Broad area of interest



Particular focus

Clear question and specific
objectives

Partnership working



Partnership working between voluntary organisations and public sector in health and social care

Partnership working between voluntary organisations and public sector in health and social care



A comparison of the perceptions of a
partnership held by members of voluntary
organisations and members of a healthcare
organisation

Research question:

What are the key differences in the perceptions of

- a) members of voluntary organisations and
- b) members of a public sector healthcare organisation

of a partnership project across the two sectors?

Research objectives

1. Review literature on partnership working across organisations, particularly across voluntary organisations and public sector healthcare organisations
2. Gather information indicating the perceptions of a partnership project held by members of voluntary organisations and a public sector healthcare organisation, which are parties to the partnership
3. Analyse this information to identify similarities and differences, and, relating this to relevant literature, indicate where perceptions may give rise to difficulties in partnership working
4. Recommend actions that could be taken to influence perceptions and improve partnership working.

Focusing....

Begin with the area or topic and narrow it down to a clear question and specific, realistic objectives

Aim for between 2 and 4 objectives

To draw up a clear question and clear objectives, think about:

1. what you are interested in researching - the broad area - and any particular issues within this area
2. what the literature says about that area, and what opportunities there seem to be for research
3. what access you have to primary research data - who/where could you get information from? what can you get information about? how could you get this information?
4. what you can realistically achieve in the time available for the research

In any topic area, there are a number of possible research projects

...but you only need to do one dissertation!

Narrowing down, focusing, often means making choices – ie to focus on a certain aspect of the situation and not to focus on another aspect

Example

Analysing the successful change project – the new training programmes

Two possible research projects:

1. an evaluation of the effectiveness of the new programmes
2. an exploration of the process of developing the new programmes and introducing them into the organisation

Which of these is the focus of the research and which is the background?

Not enough time or word-count to focus on both of them!

Option 1:

What has been the impact of the new, computer-based training programmes in XYZ organisation?

Option 2:

What factors have enabled the successful introduction of new, computer-based training programmes into XYZ organisation?

Note:

Either option could be narrowed down even further:

The impact of specific programmes

The effect of particular factors in achieving the change

Developing a question and objectives

Clarify your area of interest

What do you want to explore, or find out?

Identify different possible objectives

Assess which are most important to you, and which are most realistic. Consider what information you will be able to access.

Write, review and re-write

Further reading

*Martyn Denscombe 2007 *The Good Research Guide*, OU/McGraw Hill

Colin Fisher 2010 *Researching and Writing a Dissertation*, FT Prentice Hall: Harlow ch 1 'Choosing a topic and designing the project' pp. 31-89

Mark Saunders, Philip Lewis & Adrian Thornhill 2009 *Research Methods for Business Students*, 5th ed. Harlow, Pearson Education
an updated edition of this book is available:

*Mark Saunders, Philip Lewis & Adrian Thornhill 2019 *Research Methods for Business Students*, Prentice Hall.

#A chapter from this book is available as part of the e-resources for this module

* These are e-books in the University library